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Proposals to modernise the conservation system a good start

15 November 2024

The Minister for Conservation Hon Tama Potaka today released proposals to modernise the country's conservation system. The proposals are set out in two consultation documents and include streamlining the conservation management planning system, revamping the concession systems, providing more flexibility to exchange conservation land and charging for access to conservation areas.

"EDS has been arguing for some years that the conservation system is no longer fit for purpose, so this is a welcome first step towards modernising it," said Environmental Defence Society Policy Director Raewyn Peart.

"Conservation management planning, in particular, needs simplifying and streamlining so it is great to see that this is proposed. However, it will be important to build strong checks and balances into any new planning process, and this is why EDS has previously proposed the use of independent panels.

"We welcome proposals to revamp the concessions system to support greater use of tendering and fairer charging. Our analysis indicates that the Department of Conservation has been significantly undercharging concessionaires, given the value that access to the conservation estate provides for their businesses, so it would be great to get them onto a more equitable charging system.

"The proposal to make it easier to exchange conservation land is of some concern and needs further thought. Any exchanges need to be subject to robust considerations and should not include land with high conservation values.

"There is an urgent need for more money for conservation and EDS supports some access charging in principle. However, the details will need to be carefully worked through to ensure that New Zealanders are not excluded from accessing conservation areas.

"There's a lot of detail to digest over the coming days and we'll be responding further in due course. Submissions close on 28 Feb 2025 and we encourage the public to submit. EDS will run a webinar in the New Year to assist with that process," concluded Ms Peart.

The proposals are available to read [here](#).

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